ON SEPTEMBER 9, ***BRAHMASTRA: PART ONE—SHIVA*** earned itself a place in history. With first-day collections of Rs 31 crore for Hindi, it recorded the biggest opening for a Bollywood film since the pandemic. Seeing that it wasn't a holiday release, the feat seemed all the more impressive. Made on an estimated budget of Rs 410 crore, the Ayan Mukerji-directed fantasy action film had by day four grossed Rs 118.5 crore for Hindi, with another Rs 15.50 crore coming in from the southern states, thanks to director S.S. Rajamouli leading its publicity campaign there.

Brahmastra is now on course to dislodge *Dangal* as the highest-earning Hindi film in the South. Seen objectively, it's a great showing for a film, which for two weeks was subjected to a boycott campaign. Worse still, it also opened to mixed reviews. Though most critics praised the movie's visual effects, they were left underwhelmed by its storyline. The numbers suggest that impervious audiences were happily wowed by the action spectacle, starring Ranbir Kapoor, Alia Bhatt, Amitabh Bachchan and Shah Rukh Khan in a cameo. Even though it remains to be seen if the film's producers will recover their huge costs, they do have worldwide collections to look forward to, as also the sale of satellite and streaming rights.

The success of *Brahmastra* provides a much-needed fillip to the Hindi film industry after what's been a dismal quarter. Two star-driven titles—Aamir Khan's *Laal Singh Chaddha* and Akshay Kumar's *Raksha Bandhan*—were both colossal failures. Their poor box-office showing instantly led to a series of primetime news debates and social media discourse on how Bollywood is struggling, especially when compared to southern film industries which had made inroads into the Hindi belt with a couple of their films. Rajender Singh Jyala, chief programming officer at Inox Leisure Limited, thought this was all noise. "Social media trolls just show one side of the coin. Even their [the South's] success ratio is more or less the same as ours," says Jyala, citing the recent strike by Tollywood producers over high costs of production and low returns.

For all the talk of Bollywood being "done and dusted", PVR properties saw a footfall of 25 million between April 1 and June 30, their highest for any quarter. Jyala points out that for Inox, too, these months added up to being their best-ever quarter, in terms of footfall and box-office revenue. Some of the success came courtesy *RRR* and *KGF: Chapter 2*, yes, but also because of *The Kashmir Files* and *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 2*. Instead of Bollywood making drastic changes, the need of the hour, feels Jyala, is for Hindi filmmakers to return to larger-than-life storytelling, with strong heroes and lots of action. Collections prove that *Brahmastra* delivers on those fronts.

Brahmastra also belies the theory that boycott calls affect a film's fate at the box office. It is only content that determines

The Hit Club



BHOOL BHULAIYAA 2
Release: May 20
Earnings: ₹**181** crores

GANGUBAI KATHIAWADI
Release: February 25; Earnings: ₹**126** crore





THE KASHMIR FILES
Release: March 18
Earnings: ₹**246** crore

**Nationwide figures*
Source: boxofficeindia.com